The SCIO, at the other end of the spectrum, oversees the tie-ups and supplements in foreign newspapers which have become an important revenue stream for the increasingly cash-strapped print media in democracies. The messages that China wants to put out are carefully packaged to appear as news. The SCIO's ability to coordinate information strategy and tactics for influencing public opinion can be very helpful to China before a negotiation starts. The international community has permitted China's state-run media to use the instruments of a democratic state for perception creation purposes, all from within the confines of the Chinese diplomatic mission. At times, the Chinese media is also used to bring pressure by building nationalistic public opinion against a foreign country. This happened vis-à-vis America after the bombing of the Chinese Embassy in Belgrade in the end of the 1990s, with Japan on the Senkaku dispute and with the Philippines after the arbitral ruling on the South China Sea. The Chinese government deliberately used such public sentiment to increase its leverage in bargaining with the foreign country. The role of the *Global Times* to provoke and intimidate Indian citizens at crucial periods in India–China relations is another case in point, where the media was used by the Chinese Government to shape public discourse during a negotiation.

Chinese think-tanks are yet another instrument in the Chinese hands for influencing the outcome of negotiations. Major government and party organs in China have in-house academic and research bodies. Some, like the Chinese People's Association for Friendship with Foreign Countries (CPAFFC), the Chinese People's Institute for Foreign Affairs (CPIFA), the Chinese Association for International Understanding (CAIU) or the Chinese Association for International Friendly Contact (CAIFC), which belong to the UFWD, ILD or MFA, are platforms